
The Unserious Generation on the Most Serious Topic

Field Project · Final Presentation · SYBA English Literature

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CONTEXT

The NEET-UG 2026 Protests

01

June 6: Protests begin at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi

Led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and student groups, demanding accountability.

02

June 28: Sonam Wangchuk joins and begins a hunger strike

Alongside six AISA student activists. Police removed him from the site on July 18.

03

July 20: 'Sansad Chalo', the march to Parliament

Violent clashes with security forces. By July 23 the protests spread to Tamil Nadu, Kerala and more.

04

July 25: Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns

Seven weeks after the first demonstration at Jantar Mantar.

Demands: accountability, the minister's resignation, and relief for families of students lost to exam-related suicide.

RESEARCH

Research Question & Thesis

Research Question

What made irony and humor an effective register for political resistance in the NEET-UG 2026 protests, rather than undermining the protest's seriousness?

Thesis

Memes, reels, and Gen Z slang functioned as a rhetorical mode of political resistance, not decoration around the protest.

Framework

Multimodal discourse analysis (Hakoköngäs, Halmesvaara & Sakki, 2020), adapted to four dimensions:
Device · Target · Audience · Function.

Corpus

7 protest posters from Instagram and Pinterest (June 6 – July 25, 2026), chosen for their rhetorical richness.

Corpus: Seven Protest Posters

7

posters (Pinterest 5 · Instagram 2),
each analysed along four dimensions

Fig. 1 Spider-Man: "With great power..."

Fig. 2 "Education & System"

Fig. 3 Blinkit & Flipkart

Fig. 4 "Baddies are not apolitical"

Fig. 5 Error 404: Accountability Not Found

Fig. 6 Dora: "Kya aapko kahi accountability dikh rahi hai?"

Fig. 7 "My pad got better leak protection..."



Source: Instagram @p9xrider and @p9x_puneet_saxena

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 1

The Spider-Man Moment

"With great power comes great responsibility. Can't say the same for the Indian Government."

Device

Intertextuality + irony + parody. Spider-Man's moral lesson about power is flipped into an accusation.

Target

A government with power over education policy that failed to act responsibly, especially over the leak.

Audience

Gen Z raised on Marvel get it instantly; officials and older generations may not, which marks the gap.

Function

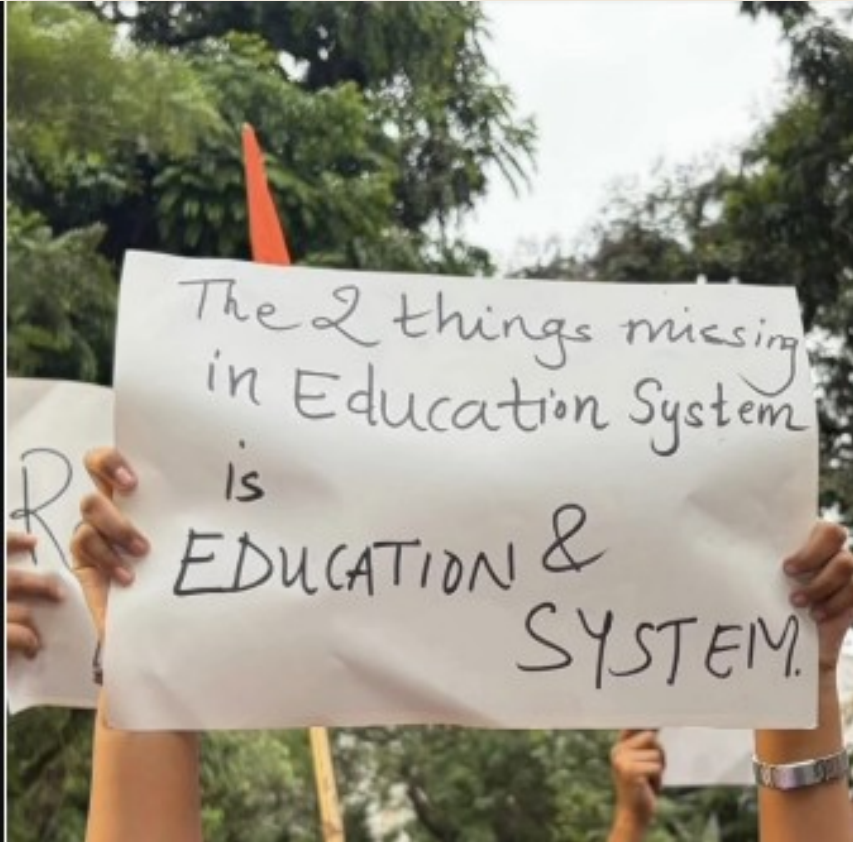
Power without accountability in one shareable line. 'Just a joke', so harder to censor and lower-risk to post.

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 2

Missing: Education & System

"The 2 things missing in Education System is EDUCATION & SYSTEM"

- Device** Wordplay + structural irony. A riddle set-up whose punchline is the institution's own name.
- Target** Total systemic failure: not one leak, but an education system that is hollow at its core.
- Audience** In-group gets the "2 things" riddle format instantly; out-group cannot dismiss it, because the joke is literally the accusation.
- Function** Compresses a sweeping critique into one self-evident line. The system is indicted by its own name.



Source: Instagram @chief.of.shitposting



Source: Pinterest @yaashnaaaa

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 3

Faster Than Your Answers

"Even Blinkit & Flipkart are faster then your answers"

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| Device | Comparative satire + consumer-culture intertextuality (10-minute delivery apps). |
| Target | Government and NTA silence and delay in answering students after the leak. |
| Audience | Urban Gen Z who order on quick-commerce apps daily; the comparison needs no explanation. |
| Function | Measures state accountability against the speed Gen Z expects from everyday life, making official delay look absurd. |



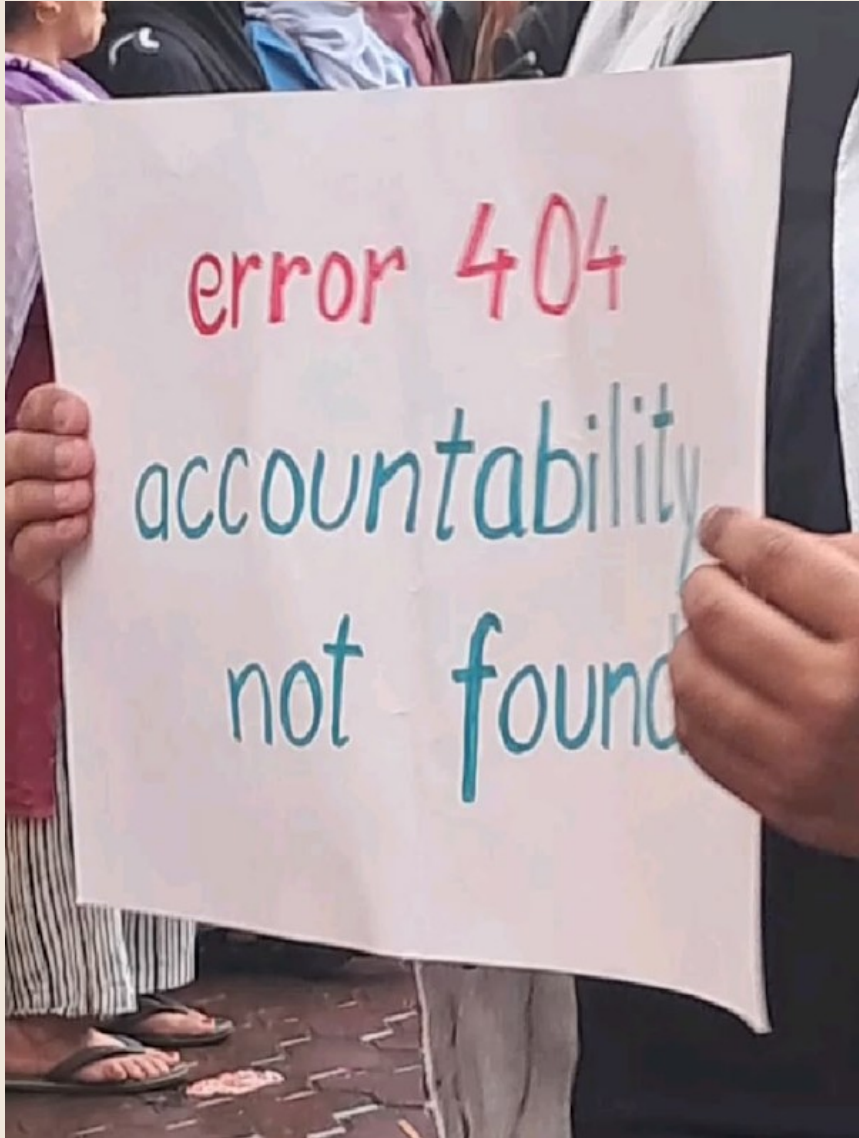
Source: Pinterest @Lyaaa

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 4

Baddies Are Not Apolitical

"BADDIES ARE NOT APOLITICAL"

- | | |
|-----------------|---|
| Device | Slang reclamation + subversion of stereotype. "Baddie" = Gen Z slang for a confident, stylish young woman. |
| Target | The assumption that Gen Z, especially young women, are unserious and apolitical, which institutions rely on. |
| Audience | In-group self-identifies with the label; elders and media are forced to revise their stereotype. |
| Function | An identity declaration: the "unserious" label becomes a political stance. The thesis of this project, on a poster. |



Source: Pinterest @FAGUN

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 5

Accountability Not Found

"error 404 — accountability not found"

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| Device | Internet/tech intertextuality (the HTTP 404 error page) + deadpan irony; "error 404" written in red. |
| Target | Absence of accountability: no minister or agency taking responsibility for the leak. |
| Audience | Digitally native Gen Z read "404" instantly; older viewers may miss the reference, marking the generational gap. |
| Function | Frames the government as a broken website: the page students need simply does not exist. Visual, compact, shareable. |



Source: Pinterest @mydearnikes

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 6

Dora Asks the Question

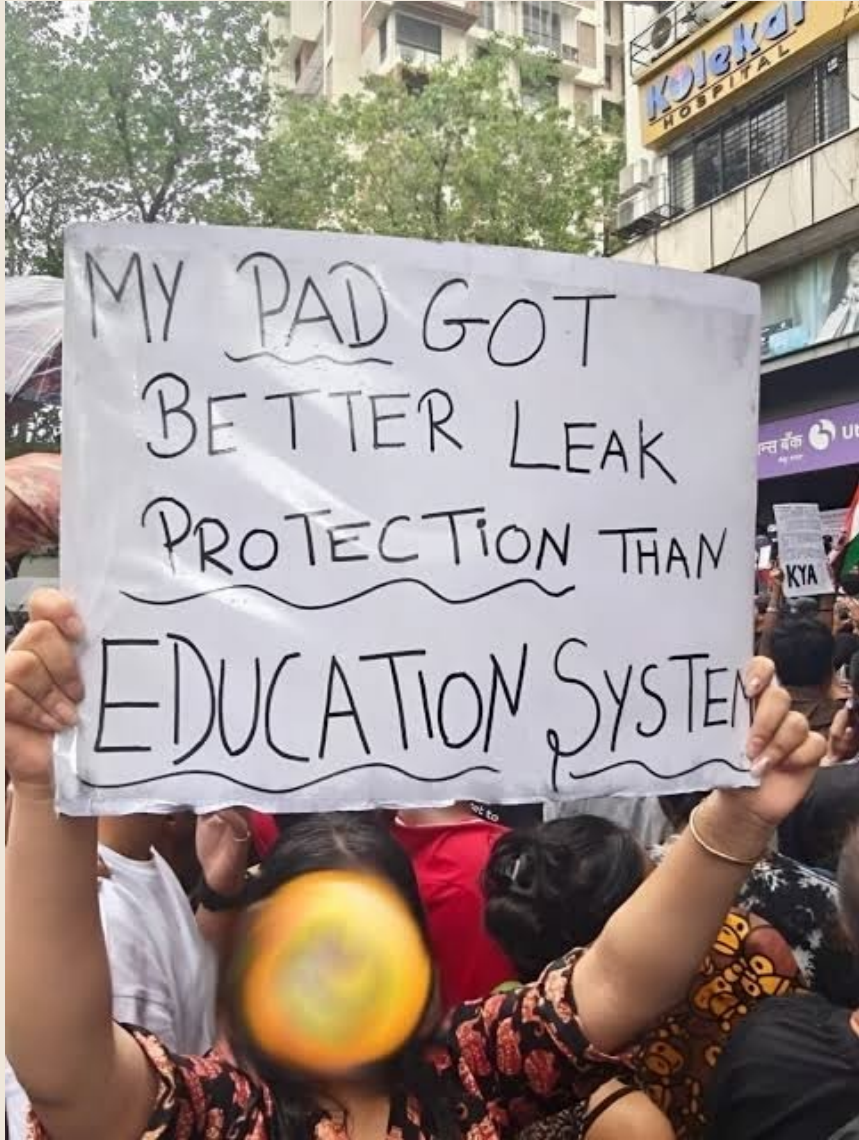
"Kya aapko kahi accountability dikh rahi hai?" (Do you see accountability anywhere?)

Device Parody of Dora the Explorer's Hindi-dubbed catchphrase + childhood nostalgia + Hinglish.

Target Invisible accountability: the government's evasion after the NEET-UG leak.

Audience Gen Z raised on Hindi-dubbed Dora; the call-and-response format pulls the viewer into answering.

Function Turns the audience into participants. The answer, "No!", is the protest, and it treats official evasion like a children's game.



Source: Pinterest @Spring potato

ANALYSIS · FIGURE 7

Better Leak Protection

"My pad got better leak protection than Education System"

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| Device | Pun on "leak" + parody of sanitary-pad advertising + dark humor that breaks the taboo around menstruation. |
| Target | The NEET-UG paper leak and the failure of exam security. |
| Audience | Young women as in-group; the out-group is jolted by a taboo subject made public. |
| Function | Shock + humor = memorable. An everyday product outperforms a national system, a comparison formal language could never make. |

EMERGING PATTERNS

Four Patterns Across the Seven Posters

Borrowed Formats

Marvel, Dora, delivery apps, 404 pages, pad ads. Familiar culture carries the critique.

Comparison as Accusation

Blinkit and a sanitary pad outperform the State. The absurdity is the argument.

Reclaimed Identity

"Baddies are not apolitical": the "unserious" label becomes political.

One Shared Target

Every item, whatever the joke, points back to one demand: accountability.

WHAT HUMOR DID

Humor as Shield, Sword & Community

Shield

“It’s just a joke”: deniable and harder to censor, while staying completely serious.

Sword

Says what formal protest language can’t: the State next to a pad, a delivery app, a broken website.

Community

The “you get it” moment is solidarity. Shared laughter turns individual anger collective.

Open to All

No policy expertise needed to make or share a meme. Anyone can join the protest.

FINDINGS

What the Seven Posters Show

3 / 7

posters point straight at missing accountability; the other four hit closely related failures

Intertextuality, irony, parody: 3 posters each

Wordplay / pun: 2 · satire, slang, dark humor: 1 each

Most humor is borrowed: Marvel, Dora, Blinkit, 404, ads

Almost every poster has a dual-layered audience

Jokes make critique short, shareable and deniable

No policy expertise needed: anyone can join in

5 of 7 posters circulated on Pinterest

CONCLUSION

Humor Carried the Protest

01

Irony

Said one thing and meant another, leaving Gen Z to complete the meaning.

02

Parody & Intertextuality

Borrowed what everyone already knew and turned it against the government.

03

Wordplay & Comparison

Made institutional failure look so absurd that it was hard to defend.

04

Slang

Turned “baddie”, a label used to dismiss Gen Z, into a political identity.

Each meme served as a tiny revolution: not decoration around the protest, but a mode of resistance.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Suggestions & Further Research

01

Institutions

Treat memes as political expression, not disrespect. Secure exams and answer students quickly.

02

Media & Older Generations

Engage with Gen Z's language. Getting the reference is the first step to getting the demand.

03

Educators

Study memes and protest posters as living satire; use multimodal analysis for media literacy.

04

Further Research

Study a larger set of posters, reels, chants and CJP's content; compare with Gen Z protests elsewhere.

Limitation: a small, purposive corpus of 7 posters, so the findings are interpretive, not statistical.

Thank You

*The unserious generation speaks seriously,
through the language they know best.*